

M6T3: Shared Visioning for Conception — 9 min

Video File M6T3-Visioning.mp4 (vision templates on screen) · **Resources** Connection Workbook.pdf — Visioning section (values sort, future-letter template, shared vision page, solo version) · **Xp** 70 total · Write Vision 40 · Share It 30

Target runtime 9 min · 1,114 spoken words · ≈ 7.4 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 8.3 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera, holding a folded letter.]

Every couple trying to conceive has a picture of the future in their heads. Almost none of them have compared the pictures. I've sat with partners who discovered, four years into trying, that one of them imagined a house full of kids and the other imagined one child and a lot of travel, and neither had ever said it. Today you compare the pictures, gently, on paper, and find out what you're actually building together.

0:30–2:30 **WHY A SHARED VISION**

[VISUAL: Slide: "Transactive goals: partners who pursue goals as a unit do better (Psychological Review)."]

Here's the science. Psychologists Gráinne Fitzsimons, Eli Finkel, and Michelle vanDellen proposed in the journal *Psychological Review* a theory they call transactive goal dynamics: in close relationships, goals stop being individual and become a shared system, where each person's efforts,

resources, and sacrifices feed the other's. Couples who operate that way, who pursue a goal as a unit rather than as two people in parallel, tend to reach it more reliably and feel better along the way. Conception is the ultimate transactive goal; nobody can do it alone. But a shared goal without a shared picture is two people pulling in slightly different directions and wondering why it's so hard.

There's also a finding about imagining the future that we touched in Module One. Hal Hershfield's research, published in the Journal of Marketing Research and elsewhere, found that people who feel connected to their future self make better long-term decisions in the present, from saving money to health choices. A vivid, shared picture of the family you're building does the same for the two of you. It makes Tuesday's vegetables mean something.

There's a quieter reason, too. Trying to conceive can shrink the future to a single question: will it happen this month? A shared vision widens the frame back out. It reminds both of you that the family you're building is bigger than one cycle, that it includes how you'll spend Saturdays and what you'll teach and who'll be at the table, and that much of that is

already happening. Couples who can see the whole picture tend to carry the monthly question more lightly, because it's one line in a much longer letter.

Visualize together. It's the emotional blueprint for your family, and blueprints get built.

2:30–7:30 THE EXERCISE: VALUES, THEN A LETTER

[VISUAL: Vision templates on screen: a values sort, a "day in the life" page, a letter template.]

Three steps, in the Connection Workbook, and they take about forty minutes together.

Step one: values, separately, then together. Each of you picks your top five from a list of thirty: things like adventure, security, faith, health, humor, learning, tradition, generosity, calm, creativity. Write them without looking at each other's. Then compare. You'll share some and differ on some, and the differences are not a problem; they're information about the family your child would actually grow up in, one with both adventure and security, both faith and humor.

Step two: a day in the life, five years from now. Each of you writes a paragraph describing an ordinary Saturday, five years on. Not the highlight reel. Breakfast. Who's up first. What's

on the table, and yes, I hope it's a fertility plate. What you do in the afternoon. Where the grandparents are. How bedtime goes. Write it in the present tense, as if it's happening. Then read them to each other, using the listening loop from Training One. Reflect before you react.

[VISUAL: Letter template on screen: "To our family, from us, before you were here."]

Step three, and this is the heart of it: the future letter. Together, write a letter to your future family, dated today. What you hope they'll know about the two of you. What you're doing right now, in this season of preparing, and why. What you promise. What you're afraid of, if you want to include it; children are allowed to know their parents were afraid and did it anyway. Keep it to a page. Sign it, both of you. Seal it, or fold it into the workbook, and decide together when you'll read it. Some couples open it at the first scan. Some read it at a first birthday. Some keep it for a hard day.

[DEMO: Cynthia reads a short excerpt of an example letter, gently.]

Here's the shape of one. "To our family, from the two of us, before you were here. We're writing this on a Sunday in autumn, and we've just come back from a walk where we talked about you. We don't know when you'll arrive, and some

days that's hard. So we're doing what we can: eating well, sleeping, clearing the house, learning to listen to each other. We want you to know that you were wanted before you were real, and that your parents were, at this moment, a team." That's a letter. It doesn't need to be more polished than that; it needs to be true.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Solo parents: the same three steps, with your circle."]

If you're doing this course on your own, whether by choice or circumstance, the exercise is just as powerful. Do the values sort and share it with a friend or family member who'll be part of your child's life. Write the day in the life with the people who'll be around that breakfast table. And write the letter from you, to your family, in your own voice. A family is anyone who shows up for the breakfast. Your vision counts just as much.

A few notes on the writing itself. Do it somewhere that isn't the bedroom or the kitchen table where the hard conversations happen: a café, a park bench, a car parked somewhere with a view. Bring the values sort, done separately in advance, so the session starts with comparing rather than generating. If one of you writes more easily than the other, the writer holds the pen

and the other speaks; both voices go on the page. And if the day in the life paragraphs turn out very different, don't reconcile them into one; keep both, and let the letter hold the overlap. Two pictures with a shared center is exactly what a family is.

7:30–8:30 SHARING AND HEART-LED CLOSE

[VISUAL: Slide: "Share your vision: with each other, then one line in the forum."]

Sharing is the second action. Read the letter to each other once, out loud, with no editing. Then post one line from your vision in the forum, the line that made you most emotional to write. You don't have to post the whole thing; the line is enough, and reading other couples' lines will remind you that you're part of a much larger family of people doing this.

This is for your future family, and this training is the first time in the course that they get a voice: a letter written to them before they're here. Keep it somewhere safe. It's the earliest thing they'll ever own.

8:30–9:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Connection Workbook → Write your vision and letter (40 XP) → Share it (30 XP)."]

Open the Visioning section of the Connection Workbook, do the values sort, the day in the life, and the future letter for forty XP, and share it, with each other and one line in the forum, for thirty. Next, Training Four: intimacy, and taking the pressure out of trying.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Connection Workbook.pdf, Visioning section (values sort, day-in-the-life page, future-letter template, solo version). **ACTION 1:** Write your shared vision and future letter (40 XP). **ACTION 2:** Share it with each other and post one line in the forum (30 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 4 · Intimacy Building Exercises.